

# The Bits Defenders

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*A chronicle in three arcs, drawn  
from a campaign I ran as Dungeon  
Master*

A CAMPAIGN CHRONICLE

*told by firststef*



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## A note before the story

I ran this game for a group of friends over three arcs and a couple of years. I was the Dungeon Master for most of it, so a lot of what follows started as my prep notes and the recaps I wrote after each night. The middle stretch I played rather than ran, so I have set that part down more briefly. Everything here happened at the table, in one form or another. I have only translated it out of my notes and my own head and tried to tell it straight through, the way a story wants to be told rather than the way a session actually runs.

The party earned the name Bits Defenders from the townsfolk who watched them fight, because of how neatly and how calmly they took a battlefield apart. It stuck. This is their story. I have set it down as one continuous thing, and I have let the person who has the best claim to tell it have the last word. That person is Mana. In the arcs I played rather than ran, Mana was my own character, an undead woman who had lost her memories, and she is the one who carries the story to its end.

*Names, places, and most of the odd jokes are theirs and mine. If a saint in here happens to be called Petrovich, well, I claimed him.*



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## The company

**Arnold** (Alex). A wizard from a distant academy, trained in the science of time. He is the reasonable one, the one who wants to solve a problem cleanly and move on, and he does not believe in much he cannot measure. He carries a small construct that does his heavy lifting and his heavy dying.



*Arnold, wizard of time*

**Gambit** (Constantin). An assassin raised on the streets of the big cities, a poisoner with a fondness for meals you only ever taste once. He needs money, he has stolen for it, and he despises other thieves. He has one dream that will not leave him alone: an army of halfling rogues, all his own.



*Gambit, the poisoner*

**Helmi** (Tan). He left home as a third son with no place waiting for him and came back a cleric of the goddess of luck, which shut a lot of mouths. Somewhere along the way he picked up a warlock's pact and a paladin's oath as well, so nobody, least of all Helmi, is entirely sure what he is anymore. A devil has a claim on him. He answers to it by refusing to answer to it.



*Helmi, cleric of luck*

**Michael** (Andrei). Rich, quiet, and always listening. His mind reaches into other minds, which makes him the best informant a party ever had and a difficult man to lie to. He is in love with a woman he barely knows.



*Michael, the listener*

**Thymir** and **Hulrig** walked the first road with them, an axe-wielding orphan and an old soldier looking for the men he fought beside. They did not walk the last one.

**Gesh** joined late, a brawler from another cursed country who can hold off five men at once and, strangely, knows what a radio is.

And **Mana**, an undead woman who had lost her memories, who was there from the start and whom almost nobody remembers being there at all.



# Book One: The Lost Mine

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It began as work, the way most of these things do.

A soldier named Sildar Hallwinter hired the company in Neverwinter to guard a supply cart down to Phandalin, a rough frontier town three days southeast. Sildar kept his reasons close. All he would say was that he had business in Phandalin with a dwarf named Gundren Rockseeker, and that a safe delivery would be worth ten gold a head. Gundren was there in the tavern too, off at his own table, pulling angry clouds from a pipe. Neither of them waited for the company to get ready. The two of them rode out at first light, in a hurry.

The company found out why on the road. The horses were down first, feathered with arrows, and around them the ground was churned with a mess of prints, most of them small and bare-footed. Goblins. And in the wreck of the ambush, half-buried, there was a dagger that gave off a cold, wrong feeling, an aura dark enough that a good god somewhere took real offense at its being used. Nobody in the party could bring themselves to wield it. They wrapped it and carried it and it sat in their packs like a held breath for a long time after.

The goblin trail led to a cave. Klarg, the brute who ran the place, was asleep when Thymir crept in and opened him up, then bolted. In the fight that followed they put down wolves and goblins both, and one goblin who wanted very badly to talk his way out of it. From him, and later from Sildar himself, the shape of the thing came clear. Gundren had found a map, the map, to the Wave Echo Cave, an old mine full of magic long thought lost. The Lords' Alliance had sent Sildar to keep an eye on both the dwarf and the map. The two had been jumped on the road by hired men, and while Sildar was hauled off as an inconvenient witness, Gundren had been left tied up for the goblins to find and drag home.

But the map was already gone, and the men who took it worked for something worse than themselves.

Phandalin, when they reached it, was a town under a boot. A gang called the Redbrands drank in the tavern like they owned it and roughed up anyone who objected, which the company took as an invitation. They cleared the tavern, hid the bodies, and started pulling threads. There was a nun at the shrine, Sister Garaele, who would not touch the cursed dagger no matter how nicely they asked, and whom Michael could not stop thinking about afterward. There was Nundro Rockseeker, one of Gundren's brothers, who filled in more of the family's story. And there was the man behind the Redbrands, a wizard who called

himself Glasstaff and turned out to be Iarno Albrek, an old acquaintance of Sildar's, which was the only reason Sildar was still alive to be rescued.

Underneath the Redbrand hideout the company found the real machinery of the plot. Gundren's other brother, Tharden, had turned on him, out of an old grudge and a promise of the mine's power. Behind Tharden was Glasstaff. Behind Glasstaff was a spider. The whole valley, it turned out, was being pulled toward a single spot by something patient and cruel that the locals only whispered about, a drow queen they called the Black Widow, or the Black Spider, who wanted the Wave Echo Cave for herself.

They chased the trail out of town and across the country. In the ruins of Thundertree they met Reidoth, a druid holding a lonely watch, and learned that the dead wood there was poisoned at the root by a green dragon named Venomfang and a twisted Gulthias tree whose blights would not stop growing. They cleared it. At Cragmaw Castle they fought through goblins, King Grol, and an owlbear before they understood that the doppelgangers had already been there ahead of them and carried Tharden and Iarno off as puppets. Back in Neverwinter, Sildar brought them into the Lords' Alliance, and the moment they said the name Black Widow out loud, a fat spider dropped into his drink, which told them exactly how far her eyes reached.



*Reidoth, druid of Thundertree*

The cursed dagger was the knot at the center of all of it. Helmi tried to destroy it once with holy fire and it would not burn, and that was the thread that unraveled the truth. A devil named Besshabar had bound the dagger to two purposes and two people. One purpose was a promise: that the blade would find and kill a thing called Infinite Darkness. The other was crueler and more personal, and the party would not learn the whole of it until much later.

Because the truth about Gundren Rockseeker was this. A demon had lived inside him. Its one purpose had been to find the Mapmaker, the only person in the world who can find anything at all, and once Gundren had the map, the thing went quiet. He came to believe the Infinite Darkness he was fated to destroy was the drow queen and her hunger for a world without light. He never understood that the darkness had been sitting behind his own eyes the whole time.

There was one night on that first road that did not belong to any of it, and that turned out to belong to everything.

## *The sleep of Twis*

They went to sleep in an ordinary place and woke in a white nothing, each of them, with a door standing at their back. Gambit was simply gone, and none of them could remember where he had been. Through each door came sounds from a memory that was not quite theirs, and when they stepped through, each of them walked a small private adventure. Thymir went down a rope into an old mine and came back up carrying a javelin that spat lightning. Helmi found a ring of standing stones under a sky full of witches and left it able to fly. Michael chased a knot of warlocks trying to steal power from a new patron, a god of time, and pried an amulet with time in its gears out of their hands. Arnold walked into a burning cathedral where the statues of the gods had turned into sword-wielding devils, and carried out a necklace of small caged fires. Hulrig went backward in time to a battlefield to save a friend who fights like a giant, and earned an armor no spell could pass through.

When they woke, it all came with them. The items were real. What had happened was this: someone had slipped a potion into their drinks, a potion that opens a door into a dream, and whatever you finish inside the dream, you keep. If you die there, you only fall into another dream. The one who had done it was called Twis, and Twis served a master they had no name for yet, a collector of stories who was running, through them, a small experiment about the shape of an adventure.

That was the first time the storyteller reached into their lives. It was not the last. And that was the night Mana slipped out of everyone's memory, because Mana had been in the party, and after that night no one could say so.

## *The Wave Echo Cave*

The last of it played out in the dark under the earth, where the mine waited. The Forge of Spells was down there, and it was not a forge so much as a wound, a place where the elemental plane of water had been stitched to the world and raw power bled through, which is why the mine had ever been worth anything at all.

The Black Widow was waiting for them, and she was not what the stories said. She went by Nezzna, a drow woman in a black crown and grey armor who floated a hand above the floor and did not need the armor to look like a queen. She had Tharden and Iarno on strings, puppets both. She had a wraith named Mormesk and a doppelganger named Vhalak, who had a nasty blessing that made him stronger the more openly he bragged about his plan. And she had a grudge that ran straight back into the party, because it was Michael's parents who had condemned her to what she had become, long ago, when they saw what she was and turned her in.

When she taunted Gundren past his breaking point, the dwarf finally let the thing inside him rise, and for a few terrible moments the party stood between Infinite Darkness and the rest of the world. A creature in the deep, a floating thing all eyes, looked at Thymir and called him by another name, Regizar, the grand architect, as if it recognized a man wearing a stranger's face. They restarted the old walls of radiant and necrotic light that guarded the forge, radiant, necrotic, radiant, necrotic, and they held, and in the end they won.

They walked out with the mine, with the survivors, and with more questions than they went in with. And somewhere in the accounting, a scythe changed hands, and a party member no one could quite name carried it out into the light.



# Between the arcs: The Truibis year

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There is a stretch here I played through rather than ran, so I will keep it short, the way you keep a thing short when you were in the room but not holding the pen. The character I played through it was Mana, an undead woman who could never keep hold of her own memories, which is perhaps why the others kept forgetting her too.

The company took work in the towns along the Triboar trail, in Yartar and its neighbors, and found a rot under the ordinary trouble. People were being taken over from the inside, low, unimportant people, a dwarf here, a laborer there, made to kill or made to die, and it had been going on for weeks. There was a discoloration in the world where it happened, a draining of color and will, and the trail of it led up through werewolves and a gryphon and a barn full of the wrong kind of clergy, up past a temple of Silvanus, to a warlock patron the corrupted ones served. They called him Truibis, the Great One.

They pulled the thread until it snapped, took their pay and their promotions in the Lords' Alliance, put money into the mine and into rebuilding the temple, and went their separate ways for a while. Mana took the scythe along. Some of the party would not walk the next road at all. But a door was already waiting for the ones who would, and it was about to open in the middle of a Neverwinter street.



# Book Two: The Curse of Strahd

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## The Library of Dreams

Helmi had walked with three others when the door appeared, unattached to any wall, standing in the open street the way Twis's doors used to. Arnold was there, and Michael, and a returning wizard named Arnold's old self, and when they stepped through, the city was gone and they were standing in a library that had no end.



*The Library of Dreams*

The librarians there were chimera, mismatched pieces of stories that had never been finished, a lion's head on a gnome's body, a woman's head on a kobold's. And at the center of it sat the one who had sent Twis into their drinks so long ago. He called himself the MythMaster, and he changed a little every time you tried to name him, because that was the shape of his power: he became whatever he was called.



*The MythMaster, keeper of stories*

He welcomed them the way he would go on welcoming them. "At last, to the center of the world. Take a seat. Have some mead." A book with blank pages opened in his hand, and he wrote in it, a small tale about a woman named Epipha who made a fine dinner, and set it on a shelf, and in the next room a magical chime sounded and Epipha herself walked out with the meal. That was what he did. He collected stories, and so he collected worlds.

He had a job for them. Travelers were being drawn into a deep mist, he said, and there their stories simply stopped. He hated an unfinished thing more than anything in creation. If someone, anyone, could go into that mist and come back out and tell him what was there, he could open a few doors and pull the trapped ones free. But no one ever came back, and for reasons he could not explain, no story told inside that mist ever reached him. All he knew was that the land belonged to a count named Strahd, that it was said to be beautiful, and that a people called the Vistani lured travelers into the fog. He could not go himself. He had, he said, restrictions in the real world. He could not touch it directly.

Helmi asked the obvious thing. Why them?

Because, the MythMaster said, according to each of their Books of Life, all four of them were going to end up in Barovia anyway, sooner or later, for reasons of their own. He had

read the reasons aloud. Helmi was searching for an angelic guide he had lost years ago. Michael would find true love there. Arnold's lost uncle was somewhere in that country. And Gambit had a wizard to kill, one who had murdered his friends.

He gave them gifts to help, and to Helmi he gave a bag of holding and said there was a story bound up in it. Then he sent them off toward the Vistani caravan and the mist, with a letter and a warning, and one of his librarians said the strangest thing on the way out, about a debt Twis had left unpaid, a story about a young wizard named Rov Melek who studied death because his brother had been murdered, and who kept calling his brother back from the grave, and kept getting back a stranger with no memories, until people began to come to him to have their own dead returned, absolved of every past sin because they no longer remembered committing them. The story stopped in the middle, which stories in that library never did. Nobody knew yet why it mattered. It mattered a great deal.

They rode into the fog. Arnold and Helmi fell asleep. Michael was taken. When they woke, they were forty feet in the air on the back of a horse the size of a house, a black horse carrying them slowly toward a pair of enormous gates, and Arnold felt the wrong thing about the light, as if he had stepped into the future. Skeletons and zombies began climbing the horse. It panicked and ran, and they clung to its back and fought and were nearly thrown off a dozen times before it reached the treeline and stopped. Its name was Troia, Helmi learned, once he could speak to it, and its whole existence was to carry travelers from the gates of Barovia to the nearest town, and it was tired, and it did not want to carry them anymore. So they killed it, for some reason. That was the first thing they did in Barovia.

They slept in a tree and woke to a creature being dragged past in chains by three undead. The creature did nothing, at first. It was called the Listener, and it was blind and deaf to everything but sound, and it had a ready strike waiting for any noise near it. When one of the undead clapped near it, the Listener turned, and in the same instant Arnold and the undead swapped places, so that the blow meant for the enemy landed on Arnold instead. It was that kind of country. When the Listener finally died, it spoke in a true tongue, and what it said was, "All I ever wanted was to be loved." It left behind an earring that could hear whispers. It looked a great deal like something torn out of a story about a man named Tomas who had bought a cursed gift and been driven mad by everything he could suddenly hear. Whether it was him, nobody could say.



*The Listener*

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## The village of Barovia

The town, when they reached it, was ugly and grieving. A castle stood on a hill above it, huge and far off. In the town hall a woman sat weeping, holding an ugly little doll to her chest. There were zombies in the streets. The people had run out of feelings. The church was dedicated to the Morning Lord and to Mother Night, but the Morning Lord had not defended this land in a long time, and so the sun never rose and the sky never cleared. It was a country God had forgotten to keep.

The doll in the woman's arms had a sinister little smile. Arnold read the magic on it and found it harmless, made to startle a child, not to hurt one. Before Helmi could try to dispel it, the doll vanished and reappeared in Arnold's own pocket, and he handed it back very quickly. On the way out of the hall they came on a hag named Morgantha stealing a child from its parents, trading in something called Dream Pastries that made a miserable life feel a little brighter for an evening. She split into three hags when they went for her, and they saved the boy and put him back in his mother's arms.



*Morgantha and her coven*

That good deed was seen by Ismark, the burgomaster's son, who needed help burying his father. The coffin was heavy and the road to the graveyard was dangerous, and no one in town would carry it. In the burgomaster's house they met Ireena, nineteen, black-haired, and not at all convinced of these strangers' competence, though she thanked them for coming for her father. Arnold's construct shouldered the coffin, and they made the walk without trouble.



*Ireena Kolyana*

The village priest was hiding someone in the cellar of his church. It was his son, Doru, turned, leaping off the walls at an impossible speed, mad and hungry. Helmi, who is very used to shielding himself from things stronger than he is, held him off and pinned him and made the priest see the truth: that in this state Doru was only being tortured, that in this cursed land no one finds rest even in death, that if Doru died he would only be born again into Barovia's mud, and that it was already hard to say whether the boy still existed at all, or whether it was only meat that moved. The priest, in the end, let his son be put in the ground. And after the two burials, a green light flooded the dark, and the spirits of everyone Strahd had ever killed rose out of the graveyard and the ditches and the alleys and walked in a column as long as the whole sad history of the place, up toward the castle, where they threw themselves into the chasm and repeated the way they had died.



*The procession of the dead*

That night the monsters came for the town, and Ireena ran to defend whoever she could, and the party ran after her and held the line. They could only stand on the last rank of the streets while the creatures came at them, and each of them had one thing they could do: Arnold could freeze an enemy in place, Helmi could shove a friend out of harm's way, Gambit could slip between everyone's legs to anywhere on the field, Michael could throw up a wall in a monster's path. If a monster got past them, the town took the wound, which was another way of saying a helpless person did. They saved eighteen villagers. Two they did not.

And then, out of the fire, Strahd came. He rode a black horse with a mane of flame and he smiled and welcomed them to Barovia. When they tried to reach him he raised a wall of fire between them. He was glad to have guests, he said, but he doubted they had the strength to survive a country so full of death, especially since they had chosen to stand against his one

true love. Still, if they lived, he would invite them to his castle. Then he galloped back into the flames and was gone, off to terrorize some other place, or haunt some other dream.



*Strahd von Zarovich*

In the morning Ismark asked them to take Ireena to Vallaki, because Strahd was hunting her, and had already bitten her twice of the three times it takes to make her his. They agreed.

On the road, at night, they watched Castle Ravenloft wrap itself in lightning, go transparent, and vanish, with a far-off boom from wherever it had gone, so that Strahd's whole host could pour out of it and fall on some other place. By a quiet river the Vistani were camped, and around the fire they told of a wizard who had once come to fight Strahd. He had been proud, and men had followed him toward the castle for war, and the moment they saw Strahd they had all run, and left the wizard to fight alone. Wizard and vampire had thrown their magic at each other from the courtyards of Ravenloft to the edge of a waterfall. Thunder shook the mountainside. Lightning struck the wizard and he held. Boulders fell on him and he held. But when Strahd himself came for him, no magic could save him, and he was thrown a thousand feet to his death, and the river carried him away before anyone could climb down to look.



*Ravenloft moves*

Then Madam Eva came out of her tent and called them each by name and said she had known their fates would cross hers. The Bits Defenders did not trust anyone tied to the people who lured travelers into strange worlds, and would not hear her, until she began to beg, and told them a thing worth hearing: that long ago, before Strahd was dark, the Vistani had saved his life on a battlefield, and for that he gave them small freedoms, like the freedom to visit worlds outside Barovia now and then, but at the end of every day they were still his prisoners too. Near to being killed, she bargained for her life with a cure. The vampire's power, she said, holds only up to the claws of death itself. If someone who had become a vampire could be brought back from death, they would return to what they had been. Softened a little, they let her read their fortunes.



*Madam Eva*

She turned the cards one at a time.

*Knowledge of the ancient will help you understand your enemy. I see a faceless god, waiting at the end of a long and winding road, deep in the mountains.*

*A holy symbol of great hope. There is a town where all is not well, a house of corruption, and within it a dark room full of still ghosts. A girl with a whip will be your key to the town.*

*A weapon of vengeance, a sword of sunlight. Look where sickness and madness are bred, where children once cried. The treasure lies still.*

*Your greatest ally will be a wizard. His mind is broken, but his spells are strong.*

*Your enemy is a creature of darkness beyond mortality. I see a dark figure on a balcony, looking down on this tortured land with a twisted smile.*

Then she read a private card for each of them. Arnold would find the one he sought when he met a gentle creature of the forest. Helmi would find his in the chapel of the castle. Michael would prove his own character alone, in a room hidden under the mountains, guarded by giants of amber. And Gambit's friends, she said, were still here, and he would learn the truth about them in the castle's library.

Further up the road they came on a warrior about to become a dead warrior, four monsters nearly on top of her. "Looks like I'll lose a bet tonight," she shouted. Her name was

Vasilisa von Holtz. They saved her. One of the monsters, a broken thing, threw out an arm that stretched and grabbed Michael and dragged him into a crushing hug, shouting "Friends! Friends!" the whole while. They killed the monsters in the end, and Vasilisa thanked them, and told them that if she still breathed by sunrise she would owe them a piece of a bet she had made with a man named Blinsky, that she could survive one night outside the town's gates.



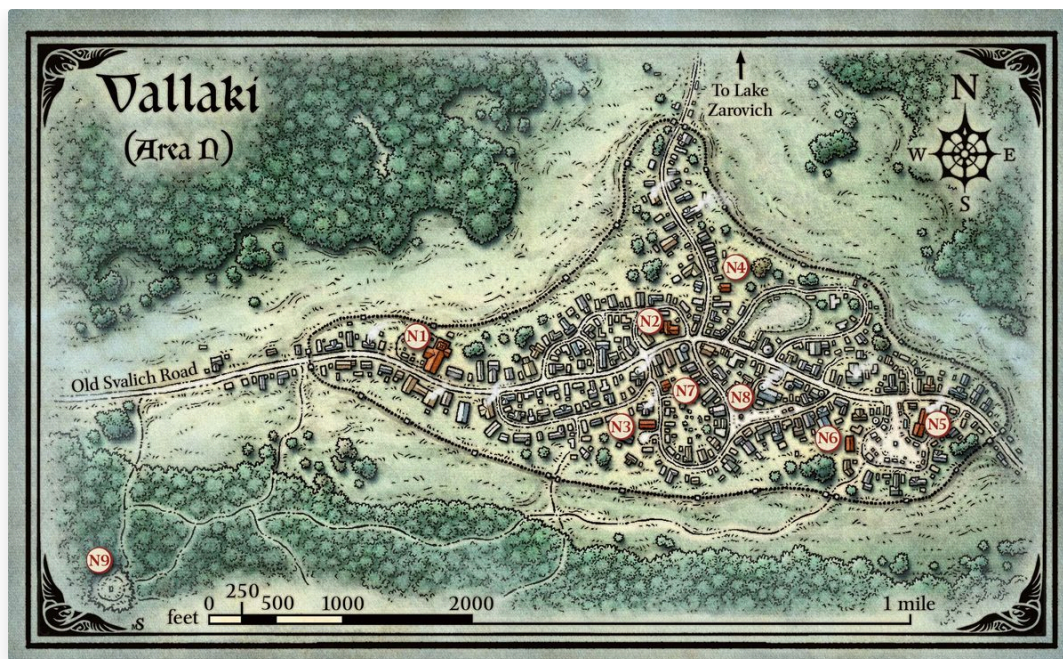
*Vasilisa von Holtz*

The guards at Vallaki would not let them in. The baroness had warned that someone would come that night to kill the baron. Vasilisa knew a better way inside, and told Helmi, who wanted to simply climb the walls like a spider, not to alert the thirty other men set to watch them.

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## Vallaki

They got in, in the end, no gate able to hold against the noble lord Helmi Fortuna, and were let through with an escort of guards who watched them very closely.



*Vallaki*

They took rooms at the Blue Water Inn and bought a great deal of anti-nightmare wine, because in Barovia there are no dreams, and so people sleep with what is left, which is the nightmares. The innkeeper, Urwin Martikov, pressed them about why they had come, and warned them the wine was nearly gone. A delivery from the Wizards of Wine was two weeks overdue, and something bad had clearly happened to it. He asked for their help and offered his own in return.

The town ran on the baron's festivals, one a week at least, on the theory that keeping spirits up kept Strahd pleased and the monsters away. In the morning a poster blew through the air announcing the Festival of the Blazing Sun.

They went with Vasilisa to settle her bet at the toy shop, and met Blinsky, a cheerful man in a mannequin's costume hoping for new customers. On his shelves Ireena found a doll that looked exactly like her, down to the armor, and beside it two dolls holding hands, one a bride in a bloodstained gown. Blinsky had no idea where the likeness of Ireena came from, only that inspiration had struck him. The others he knew. "Everyone has heard, in songs and stories, of Tatyana and Sergei. Before Barovia was this closed land, Tatyana was a beautiful girl of good family, whom Strahd thought worthy to be his wife. But no matter how many gifts he brought her, she chose Sergei, his younger brother. Some say the two of them fled. Wiser people know that nothing and no one escapes Strahd. Their fate is unknown, but they have not been seen for, well, a very long time."



*Blinsky the toymaker*



*The Ireena doll*

Blinsky's purple dolls, it turned out, had a power. Parents bought them for their children, and they would play little games and appear when a child was sad, and when no one was watching they went looking for other people to play with. If you found one, it could help you reach a hidden potential of your own, under certain rules. The first to touch it received the gift. The gift appeared embroidered on the doll's dress as a scene, and could only be used the way the scene showed it. On the doll's back was a date it would expire. And the doll always asked for payment: an answer to a question, given honestly, from the heart. A true answer bought a more generous gift next time. A false answer, or none, bought a stingier one. These dolls would follow the company through the whole of Barovia, and become one of their strangest weapons.

There was a church in Vallaki, St. Andral's, where Ireena was taken for safety, said to hold the bones of a saint that protected the town. The bones had been stolen. The priest, Father Lucian Petrovich, asked them to find them and suspected a boy, Milivoj, who helped around the church but had a short temper. While the others questioned the boy and got nowhere, Gambit slipped into Milivoj's room and found a little girl in the bed, gravely sick. He put his own amulet of health around her neck, and she was cured on the spot and ran out to tell her brother. The boy's anger turned to gratitude and then to guilt, and he admitted he had stolen the bones. The coffin maker had paid him to do it, so he could pay for his sister's treatment.

The coffin maker, Henrik, when they ambushed and questioned him, told the rest. A well-dressed man had come to him a month before and threatened his daughter's life, and in exchange for her safety Henrik was to let the man use his cellar and never go down there himself. There were noises at night. He did not go and look. Recently the same man had left a letter ordering him to steal the saint's bones, which he had done. Behind a wall in the cellar the party found vampire spawn and skeletons and a portal that only led one way, inward. Helmi cast a false daylight that tore the vampires apart, and they destroyed the circle and took the bones (minus two fingers of the saint, which Gambit kept to make his poisons stronger) back to the church, where a holy ward snapped into place around it. Ireena chose to stay there, under its protection.

They met a traveler named Rictavio in the market, a man who claimed to come from other countries and carried wooden stakes and garlic and holy water, the tools of a monster hunter. He let slip that he had come to Barovia from other lands of the mists, and changed the subject fast when asked whether you could reach those lands from here. And they visited House Wachter, where Fiona Wachter told them she would sooner serve the devil than a madman like the baron, and read devilish books with her friends. Her daughter Stella had lost her mind and believed herself a cat, after the baron's son treated her cruelly, a wastrel who does nothing but pore over old spellbooks all day. Helmi healed Stella, and in gratitude Fiona let him take one of her books off her hands. She hinted the sun festival

might be worth attending, and would not say why, only that a friend had assured her the baron would be made a fool.

The festival was compulsory. The baron gave a speech about how the sun was not in the sky but in their hearts, and how this would please Strahd, to a crowd that did not sound convinced. The great ball of oil-soaked material in the plaza was meant to be lit, but rain came, and the torchbearer slipped and put out the flame, and the crowd laughed, and the baron raged and ordered the laughers arrested. When his men reached Helmi, one of them burst into flame.



*The Festival of the Blazing Sun*

At that same moment the clouds tore open and moonlight fell on the plaza. People began turning into sword-wielding skeletons among the crowd. Michael heard a whispered voice nearby say two words, "Heavenly Fireball," and a flame fell from the sky into the oil and lit it, and out of the fire a creature came, smiling and smiling at the terrified crowd. Then a second, and a third, each worse than the last, and monsters stitched together out of old rags that could change your clothes when they hit you. Arnold heard, from behind one of the creatures, a small voice say "Is no fun, is no Blinsky," and saw a purple doll pinned to its back, and pried it free with a spectral hand and dove for cover. The baron was saved by a

huge man with a hand of fire. In the end they put the creatures down. But they had all felt it: something was reaching into this town through its dreams.



*Creatures out of the fire*

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## The Nightmare World

The baron, tangled in the rags of the monster that had nearly strangled him, was freed by Izek, the man with the burning hand. Ungrateful, the baron looked around the ruined plaza where only the party remained and called for his men. "Seize them. They came to attack the festival."



*Izek Strazni*

Helmi raised his hand. "Daylight." And every street in Vallaki lit up like a fine summer day, and women and children came out of their houses to stare at the globe of light hanging over the plaza and at everything bleached bright beneath it. "I have come as the Emissary of the Morning Lord," Helmi said, "to save this festival. Can you not see?" The baron was silent a moment, then fell to his knees praising the god who had brought them light. "This is what the Festival of the Sun is about. Light from the sky. The Morning Lord and Strahd have answered our prayers, and today we have the light of hope."

They gathered what the monsters left behind. Among it was a stone that would only bind itself to someone at the door of death, that could roll to a spoken command, that gave off light of its own. A radiant stone, from the heart of one of the constructs.

That night Arnold and Helmi lay down to sleep and instead found themselves standing in a decayed city under a lifeless sky, among hideous plants. Michael, in his waking-sleep, saw that the mental threads that ran from him to the other two now ran into two openings that led somewhere else. He woke Arnold, confirmed it, sent him back into the dream, and then reached out with his own mind and touched one of the openings, and it pulled him in.

The Nightmare World was a place with no bodies and no wounds, only minds. What held you there was your own resolve. A blow did not take blood, it took your composure, and different kinds of harm pressed on different feelings: cold made you lonely and distant, fire made you furious, poison made others distrust you, guilt sharpened you against yourself. And into that grey dream a figure grew out of the smoke, tall and calm and cruel, and spoke.

"At last. You pull yourselves free of the sea of faces. You who ruined my plans and dared to defy the natural order. I, Sehanine Nightweaver, have found you." Her voice was soft, almost soothing, and stitched through with a cold that reached into the soul. "You have made waves in the still waters of Vallaki, disturbing the neat scheme of fates. Who sent you?" And their thoughts rose into the air, unstoppable, in their own voices, and Michael's answered before he could stop it, MythMaster, and she laughed. "Ah. Emir the mad enemy sent you." She promised them her eyes would follow them into the deepest dark of their dreams, that she would peel back their courage and find each of their fears, that she was the mistress of the night and they her prisoners. Then she vanished.



*Sehanine Nightweaver*

A white fox appeared and called them to follow. It hid Michael behind broken walls and introduced itself as Moon Bow, and told them that it and Nightweaver were both bound to this world, and that when one grew weak the other grew strong. It told them that dying here would not kill them, only leave them carrying the wounds of the mind, and that to escape you had to hold a single happy memory for four minutes.

Meanwhile, in the waking world, something grabbed Helmi's body. He opened his eyes on a hideous thing crouched over his bed, one foot still inside his bag of holding. The Bag Man. It bit and clawed and Helmi answered with a clap of thunder that woke the whole inn, and Michael froze the old horror with a wand, and Arnold, sick with the mind-wounds he had taken, remembered a doll that could turn time back ten minutes, and used it. He came back to before the fight, warned his friends, and this time they took the Bag Man cleanly. But first, with the time he had, each of them held a happy memory to get free of the dream. Arnold's was coming home and being praised for freeing Phandalin. Helmi's was returning as a cleric and proving everyone who doubted him wrong. Michael's was his father telling him

and his brother and sister stories, one of the few times the man had truly seen him, and perhaps the reason he loves history so much now.



*The Bag Man*

At the baron's villa they found worse things than a rude host. Michael slipped in invisibly while Helmi and Arnold kept the baron talking. There was a mirror the baron did not want anyone near, and Izek's room was full of dolls that all looked like Ireena, and a note on the desk announced the next festival was already planned, the Happy Carnival. Arnold worked out what the mirror did and spoke the rhyme, and an assassin stepped out of nowhere and asked who they wanted killed. The last man he had been sent to kill, he said, was a political rival of the baron's. The baron shrank, and called him a liar, just an assassin. When Arnold said the name "Strahd," the count's face appeared in the glass, mocking their cowardly method and inviting everyone in the room to dine at his castle, and binding the baron with a compulsion to come. Helmi shattered the mirror.

Higher up, they found the baron's son, Viktor, practicing magic with skeletal cats, standing over a glowing circle. He sneered that he could make portal circles and Helmi could not. Helmi said it should be tested, and Viktor invited him to try it, so Helmi sacrificed his familiar Kyros into the circle, which vaporized the poor creature into nothing the instant it activated. The baron reminded Viktor, wearily, to stop pulverizing people. Arnold, more diplomatic, traded spells with the boy, who turned out to be far more capable than he looked. And in a dusty attic, from a whispering chest, Michael pulled the Holy Symbol of Ravenkind, an ancient weapon against vampires and a real turning point in their road.

That night, on the way east to the Wizards of Wine, a deer stepped into their path and led them up into the mountains, then rose onto two legs and spoke to Arnold. "You will die on day five of the blue moon in year 735." Then it became a man who shouted, "You think my magic has grown weak?" The fight ended almost before it began. "You have beaten me. How can you do this, to me, who was once the greatest. How can you do this, to poor Mordenkainen?" The legendary wizard, now only a fraction of himself, had been hiding here,

in his own hidden mansion, waiting to recover a piece of his mind that had been broken off and lost somewhere in the heart of Barovia.



*Mordenkainen, unmade*

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## Mordenkainen's mind

He invited them into his mansion, a whole grand house you enter through a single magic door. He did not know exactly where he had lost his mind, only that it was somewhere dark and full of ash, and that since then he had stopped having nightmares, so he could not have found his way back to reclaim it.

He told them three things he had come here seeking. He had hunted an arcanaloth through the mountains, one of those clever, dangerous beings that stir up trouble whenever the great Cosmic Balance is at stake, but it had judged him unworthy, turned itself into a man, and fled into the wild. He had learned that Strahd let no one leave, that this whole land was the count's toy, and had decided to stop him, refusing some project Strahd wanted his help with. And in the old books of the country he had found mention of the Dark Powers, the original source of Strahd's strength, whom no one truly knows. He gave the party the task of recovering his mind, and hinted at help in return. And he looked hard at Gambit and remembered a band of halflings from Neverwinter who had once tried to steal an artifact from him, whom he had chased right into this realm, who had fought beside him against Strahd, and whom he had not seen since.

Michael took Mordenkainen into the Nightmare World, and a glowing rabbit led them to a great chasm, at the bottom of which lay a huge burning fiend, red and horned and winged, weeping. This, the rabbit said, was Strahd. It called itself Moon Bow, told them its power

was fading and it might not appear here much longer, and led them instead to a house where Mordenkainen's mind was kept.

Inside the House of Lost Paths, thoughts of misery drifted in the air, "I hate this," "why," "I wish I could die," spoken by nightmare things that guarded the place. They could not sneak, because their own thoughts leaked out ahead of them. Arnold pulled Michael through a doorway between spaces up to the second floor, where a strange creature was grinding a ball of light, and jars of light floated on every wall. The creature spoke. "You have come to recover what you think is yours, Mordenkainen. But the part that stayed in this world tore itself away from you. When we act against a part of ourselves, that piece can be lost in the unknown of our own mind. This is the price of your pride." Michael did not listen. He grabbed four jars off the shelves in one motion and flipped to safety. The dog-nightmares fell into blue crystals when killed, and the rabbit told them to gather the crystals quickly, and Helmi realized his bag of holding was glowing softly. "Put the jars in the bag," Mordenkainen shouted, and they crammed jars and crystals into the sack until the monsters forced them awake.

Back in the waking world, Arnold studied the jars. A person could reintegrate a lost part of their mind by spending a few days in contact with the light inside the jar. The jars held Mordenkainen's memories, and three others: someone at a table fixing a button to a doll, and the doll beginning to dance; a creature flying through night clouds, raising a glowing hand and calling down a great ball of fire onto a market of people; and a man strapped to a table, a saw catching the light and biting into his arm, blood on his face, and then only darkness. The crystals, Arnold found, could push a person's abilities past their normal limits. They called them Memory Shards. One was larger and violet, and it had its own name, an Ash Shard.



*A Memory Shard*

To be sure Mordenkainen would not turn on them when his memories came flooding back, Arnold agreed to become his disciple and take his badge, so the old wizard would know him under any circumstances. And the bag of holding, Mordenkainen noted, was very strange indeed. It should not do this. Normally a bag of holding would work as a kind of in-between space, between the nightmare world and the real one.

They went on toward Krezk, on the way to the Wizards of Wine. Krezk had high stone walls and enormous crossbows that turned to follow them, and its captain, Jatko, would not

let them in without a good reason, and suggested that bringing back the wine might be reason enough.

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## Blood and wine

Near the Wizards of Wine they saw a winged figure flying over a great vineyard. Helmi used one of the dolls' gifts to teleport above it and bind it in chains, and saw that its eyes were black, the mark of Sehanine Nightweaver's corruption. They cured it and gave it back the memories from one of the jars, and it told them it was Invictus, the Abbot, a celestial with no god, who had chosen to become a god himself for Barovia. He had been driven out of Krezk after trying to save its people, who refused to see the light. He worked now with druids who had promised to follow him in exchange for his help keeping nature's balance, and one of those tasks had been to destroy the source of the wine, which had been found impure, an offense against nature itself.



*Invictus, the Abbot*

He took them down into the vineyard, where the grapes were red as blood, grown by servants of Strahd who had learned to turn blood into wine. In the house at the center of the vines was a hole with bleeding edges, and below it a maze of caves whose walls looked like living flesh. Invictus killed a druid gorging himself at a barrel of blood, and the rest attacked, and they were cut down fast. And out of the deep came four creatures covered in muscle and veins, and a man who worked blood as magic.



*The cave of flesh*

Deeper still they found an old man in a hut in the cave wall, eyes closed, who did not react. Michael reached into his mind wearing Strahd's voice and asked for the whole story.

"Strahd had the Vistani bring us. Some of us were tricked, others came because life had already betrayed us. Wizards from other lands, Dementlieu, Borca, Falkovnia, and he forced us to make blood to feed a vampire's power. Years passed, and one night he came and gave us a special blue crystal, and told us to plant it and grow a vineyard over it. The moment we planted it, the crystal began to drip blood and grow veins, and the vine grew unnaturally fast, fed by the crystal's blood, so fast that in a few months we could harvest. And the very moment we crushed the first grapes, three carts drawn by black horses came to take the wine. We studied the crystal, and saw that it feeds. At first we gave it plants and animals, but then someone fed it a captured thief, and it was never the same. The walls began to grow flesh, and now and then a creature is born out of the swelling of the cave. Strahd meant to use them for his army. I am the last of us who has not tasted the crystal's blood. They still send me when they need to speak to people from outside."

They killed the old wizard, Davian, and pulled the blue crystal out of a formation shaped like a huge heart. When Arnold tried to read it, he saw a dream: a mother and her daughter, and a suitor refused, who stole the daughter out of spite and carried her into Hell. The

mother went searching but was too late; when she found the body it was already eaten by worms and rotted. She wept until she had no tears left, and then she wept blood, and the dream ended on a sea of blood. The crystal made blood by consuming what was around it. Feed it something living, and it gave much more. They cured the poisoned wine with a flower that grows beside a Gulthias tree, Kyros flying it back from the druids' grove, and Gambit neutralized every barrel.



*Davian, last of the winemakers*

In the Nightmare World, Sehanine Nightweaver came again for the minds they had taken, calling up monsters each shaped from a different fear. They killed them and took more shards, and Arnold looked into one of the houses there, a library, and found that all the stories in the books had been erased, the pages blank.

Krezk let them in at last. In its inn they met a talking head kept alive by a doctor in the hope of one day restoring the man it belonged to, and Esmeralda and Lenna, who were organizing a Resistance, a group training to one day beat Strahd, and Kushk, a lizardfolk with a fondness for beer who handled the Resistance's recruits and money. And they heard the local rumors. The abbot of the monastery had been driven out two years ago by a Doctor Emil Bollenbach, who exposed him as a non-human creature who only wanted the people of Krezk to worship him. When the abbot turned into an angel and attacked, the doctor struck him down with a great lightning bolt and drove him off, and since then the townsfolk had begun sickening, and many believed the abbot had cursed them. A condemned killer had been handed to the doctor as a test subject, given monstrous limbs, and then released, and now hid deformed and desperate in the trash. Children at the monastery, someone said, played with strange and dangerous creatures.

At St. Markovia's Abbey they met Sister Alcha and a blind old woman, Marzena, caring for the children. While Helmi kept them busy with sweets and fruit, Michael searched, and in the cellar found a heavy door and behind it hideous, misshapen creatures, and a wall with a golden platter set into it hiding money, a potion, and a little statue of St. Markovia. He could not lift the platter back, and it made a noise, and the creatures came up, thinking it was playtime. One of them, Zyfried, had a lizard's hand. The party realized the jarred memories might belong to one of these creatures, and when Helmi recalled a detail from the flying memory, a tattoo on the chest, Zyfried said yes, he had a tattoo on his chest, and they gave him his memories back.



*Zyfried of the Belview*

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## The doctor of Lamordia

At the orphanage a creature with a crab's claw and a second head, Clovin, asked the heroes to find his friend. The friend's name was Sergei, and he was a living sword. Clovin used to talk to Sergei through a crack in the wall by the gold-lidded vault, but ever since the doctor had come through, he could not hear him, and thought the doctor had taken him.

Back in town, at the Resistance's training ground, they watched a fighter named Gesh hold off five men at once. Helmi challenged him to a duel, and while the others got bored, Arnold played a prank and paralyzed Helmi at exactly the wrong moment, and Gambit recruited a halfling into his own private army of halfling rogues, which he named the Gamblers. When Michael asked Esmeralda about Lenna, nobody could remember who Lenna was. It was as if her existence had been erased. They took Gesh with them, telling him his skills were wasted staying safe here. Michael linked to his mind and found that Gesh, somehow, knew what a radio was, and listened to music that also existed in this world. Three weeks ago, Gesh said, some Vistani had stolen his gold, and while he chased them through a forest, werewolves had torn a thief's arm off. Gesh had picked up the fallen arm and gone after the man to give it back, "you dropped something," and then the fog had come, and he had woken in Barovia.



*Gesh*

They paid the doctor a visit. There was a light in the tower of his manor, a person-shaped light standing in the middle of the room, and they climbed to the window. Out of the light stepped a creature with a wicked bearing, an arcanaloth, who looked each of them over and counted their souls aloud, eleven, eleven, five, ten, nine. "You have great power inside you, but in my pouch I have a hundred souls to spend on spells. You would do well to accept my deal, and leave with your lives. Anything you want, wealth, power, fame, for your soul." They

refused and attacked, but a wall of force protected him, and he teleported back to a portal. "I will wait for you at the Amber Temple." Behind him he left two hundred gold and a book, a Book of Keeping of demons, a list of names tied to demons, and under the heading Besheba, crossed out, the old name Besshabar, and beneath it, written in red, a name they knew: Gundren Rockseeker. And a set of manuscripts on how to erase a person from existence, which said that someone must be a vessel who receives the erased person's fate, and that the spell can be undone if the vessel is killed, or if the vessel speaks the true name of the one who was erased.

They went down into the manor. A voice came through the pipes. "Welcome, dear uninvited guests. I am Doctor Emil Bollenbach, the most skilled craftsman of life in Lamordia." A puppeteer with two battle-puppets on chains met them, and flesh golems came out of the walls, and the clicks they thought were saw-blades turned out to be traps collapsing the floor. They beat the puppeteer. The voice laughed. "You have beaten my puppet. That is nowhere near what I can do." Michael found a magic sword in a cabinet and gave it to Gesh, and they went down through the broken floor.



*The Puppeteer*



*Doctor Emil Bollenbach*

In the boss room the doctor stood far off with a shining sword in his hand, speaking to it. "Look, Sergei, these are the ones who will lose their lives because of you." A flesh colossus tore itself out of the wall to block them, and the doctor turned and went down into a room behind the cave. The colossus was enormous, built of many bodies, and it smashed the tunnel behind them, but Gesh and Helmi climbed it and struck at its eyes, its weak point, and it flung them off. Gambit teleported past it and went after the doctor, who was staring into a strange vessel that seemed to hold floating soap bubbles. Gambit struck him with celestial blood, which delighted him, "ah, celestial blood, delicious, exactly what I need," and he drove a syringe of boiling purple into his own throat, and his veins swelled and his breath came out as white steam. They killed the colossus at last, and the doctor looked into his sea of bubbles and whispered, "It seems I have no way to survive, only to face my death like a man." Then he shouted, "I surrender," and threw himself at their feet.



*The Flesh Colossus*

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## The Reality Machine

They tied him up. But his eyes went strange, looking through them, and he spoke in a cold, ethereal voice, and then a warmer one, and the two argued through his mouth.

*(the neutral, distant voice)* "Ah, the so-called heroes. You think that by capturing this fragile body you have won a victory. He is only a tool, a means to an end."

*(the melodious voice)* "Do not listen to her. The Divine Memory Genome was made to help you, to give you a chance against the darkness threatening this world."

*(neutral)* "The genome. The Reality Machine. An interesting toy, nothing more. Heroes come and go. My power remains."

*(bright)* "They are brave and determined. Do not be blinded by indifference. Do not underestimate them."

*(neutral, calm)* "We shall see. So far all I have seen is an endless cycle of effort and failure."

*(gently)* "And I trust them. They are the hope of this world."

The doctor's head dropped, and when he raised it he seemed to wake from a trance, his eyes clearer, though still flecked with blue and black. Afraid now, he pleaded. He had done the experiments for Strahd, who wanted an invincible army to conquer all the lands of the mist, and who had promised protection and endless resources. But he saw now that he was

wrong. He could offer them what he knew. Strahd had poured enormous work into Castle Ravenloft, turning it into a machine capable of teleporting long distances, so he could move his base anywhere in the blink of an eye. And the strange vessel of bubbles, he said, he had built at the command of a voice in his head, which told him it would one day be useful to certain heroes.

On the cold floor of the laboratory, a shining blade caught their attention, its light pulsing almost like something alive. As they came near they heard a faint whisper. "Help. Lift me up." Helmi picked it up, and a clear, strong voice rang in every mind present. "Thank you, brave travelers. I am Lord Sergei, brother of Count Strahd. Once I was a man, but fate has made me this. I was killed by my own brother, and when I woke I was this sword. I was a prisoner for a long time, used as a tool by cruel hearts. I am deeply grateful you have freed me from that doctor." He warned them of tormented souls in the rooms above, innocents dragged into the doctor's lab by creatures of living flesh.



*Sergei, the Sunsword*

Michael, in a changed shape, tried to slip through a room of dark figures, humanoid shadows leaking black smoke, one chained to a bed. A deep voice filled the room, Sehanine's, speaking through the creatures. "You. You are not under my control." Their eyes flared red, and out of them came monsters from the Nightmare World, and the party, still spent from the colossus, had to fight them here in the waking world. When one fell, a shadow trembled and its right eye turned blue, and a little blue sparrow flew out, dove into the vanishing corpse, and shot back to the surface scattering blue crystals. A violet Ash Shard dropped by Gambit's foot, and the sparrow told him to use it, but he hesitated. Helmi called out, "Are you Moon Bow?" and a soft voice answered in their minds, "Yes. Use the crystals to destroy the creatures Nightweaver has brought into this world." One beast

rained acid blood on all of them and said, "I am the echo of the minds you killed in the wizards' cave, and now I take revenge for every creature you crushed." Helmi felt the weight of every thing he had ever put down, and steadied himself, and they killed it.



*Moon Bow's sparrow*

In a hidden storeroom, eight people floated in cylinders of green liquid, unresponsive. One of them was Lenna. The rest were villagers of Krezk.

And Arnold finished studying the doctor's strange vessel, the Divine Memory Genome, the Reality Machine. Each bubble was a living thing, and each was a possible reality. Bubbles near each other were near-identical worlds. The bigger a bubble, the more likely that reality. Touch one, and you were carried into it in your mind.



*The Reality Machine*

Helmi found himself in a ruined field, Strahd's castle destroyed in the distance. It was the future, and he half-remembered it. After Strahd was killed, a vast army of creatures with weapons that shone brighter than the sun had come through the mist, and at their head marched the MythMaster. In a single day they captured every conscious creature in Barovia and gathered them together so that not one was left for Sehanine to hide inside, and they found her hiding in the mind of Ismark. The MythMaster fitted a strange device over Ismark's eyes that opened a door into the Nightmare World, and came back out looking very satisfied. "Thank you, dear heroes, for bringing me my happy ending. For anyone who wants to know what I did in the Nightmare World, I took Sehanine's power for myself. Now, at last, I can repair this universe. But I cannot let you leave. You would stand in my way, and, knowing you, you would most likely beat me. I have convinced the Dark Powers to hold you here for the moment. For you, that moment will mean the rest of your lives. It was a fine adventure. Do not be sad." Helmi tried to walk through the mist and reached nowhere, and returned to the waking world exhausted by the vision.

The others touched bubbles too and saw other futures. Gesh saw the party fighting off invaders from beyond Barovia, heroes come through the mist to conquer or destroy them, and Strahd put in chains but not killed. Gambit saw Strahd win, the whole party in a cell, and himself pretending to surrender only to be crushed the instant he reached for the count's door. Helmi saw a winter with no end close over them on the mountain road, and Helmi saw himself open a chest and become a lich.

They remembered the manuscript on erasing a person, and understood how to bring Lenna back. Kill the vessel, or speak the erased one's true name. The doctor was the vessel. But Lenna was only a short name, a pseudonym, and speaking it did nothing. Lenna wore a locket, and it was magical, and it would open only to her true name, which was written

inside its own enchantment. They forced the doctor to say it, all of it: *Lenn'aeloria Vys'andrel Thyr'elune Sel'andra Mor'elith Lun'arielle Ryn'endora Eil'arisha*. A globe of white light came from the southeast and entered her chest, and Lenna woke in Michael's arms with no memory of anything before the dark, and thanked him. Helmi killed the doctor and burned him, and seven rays of light came down from the southern mountains and returned the villagers to life.

They slept, and were pulled into the Nightmare World, and Sergei was there. They searched for Moon Bow and could not find her, until a blue worm called them over, weaker now, and they asked how to keep her from disappearing entirely.

And in the dark, in Strahd's hands, they saw Ireena, asleep, carried by a great winged demon that Strahd had become. Sergei fixed his blue eyes on her. "Tatyana." At the name, she stirred, her lips moving as if to answer. But before anything else could happen, Strahd clapped his great clawed hands, and in a burst of dark energy he and Ireena vanished, leaving only the echo of Sergei's cry.



*Strahd takes Ireena*

When they woke, Kyros confirmed it. Ireena was gone from the church, though the saint's bones were still there. Vasilisa had visited her the night before, and neighbors had heard Ireena say something very suspicious, "if you allow me to enter." Politeness, in Barovia, is how you become a vampire.

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# The Amber Temple

They set out for the temple in the mountains, the faceless god at the end of the long and winding road. Mordenkainen came, but warned them he would only ever be a supporter from the shadows, because he had had his fill of adventures and would not steal the joy of theirs.

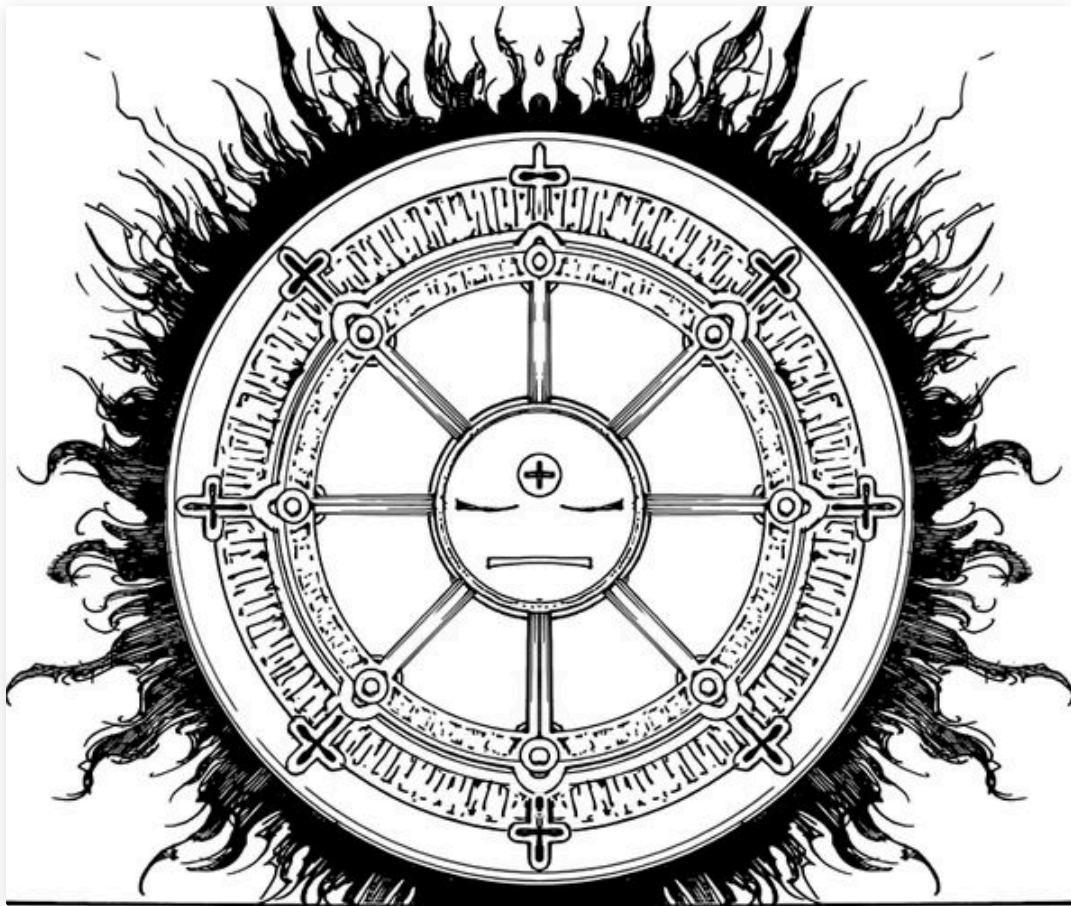
They crossed a phantom bridge held by five ghosts of Strahd, and won a handful of odd, temporary tools off it: a powder that lays a slick of ice, a coin that pulls metal, a stone that hovers, an eardrum that lets you swap places with a nearby object at a clap. Then they climbed Mount Ghakis into a blizzard, and Arnold conjured a warm hut when the cold began to win. Something in the storm was watching them. Helmi realized it was the very place they had been trapped in one of the Reality Machine's futures. Everything around them was thick with magic. Arnold read the ground and it answered that the monster was charmed. Michael reached out to whatever it was and found only feelings, and calmed it, and the storm eased a little. But Gesh wanted to test it, and struck the ground with a critical blow, and a fist the size of a house rose up and flung them all into the air, hut and all. The whole mountainside for two miles around was one living thing, a genius loci, and Arnold, stepping into the ethereal, saw there was no going through it. Helmi stripped the charm off it, and from that point the storm went quiet.



*The living mountain*

On the road they heard a thin metallic ring and found a strange coin. When they touched it, a creature appeared beside them, a huge wheel floating in the air, and did nothing but wait. Michael remembered an old story: that people who have seen their own fate, by fortune-telling or by divine light, draw such beasts to them, and the beasts follow, feeding on the

excess of magic that gathers around a person about to meet their future. This was a Fate Beast, the Coin Beast, ethereal to all but the closest friends of the one it followed. Once a day it spat out a coin worth a little more each day, and if you fed a coin back into its mouth it granted a boon, and learned to build a thing. It seemed to have chosen Gambit, drifting silent behind him.



*The Coin Beast*

Above the temple door a plaque read: *I made this temple long ago, to store the full magical knowledge I have amassed. Many tried to wield it. If you are worthy, you may enter. Exhander.* They chose not to be worthy, and went around the side rather than through the front, where a room of traps and amber golems waited (they took the trapped route once, and left with a very fine amber serving platter). Through the side they fought berserkers and flame skulls, found a complete model of Castle Ravenloft built by its original architect, and made careful sketches of it so they would understand the whole structure. In the central hall the arcanaloth Inajira was ready for them, wrapped in a wall of shifting color. Mordenkainen teleported Gesh inside the wall, but the arcanaloth was untouchable by magic weapons unless a certain square of the floor was occupied, so Michael went invisible and stood on it, and together they cut the creature down.



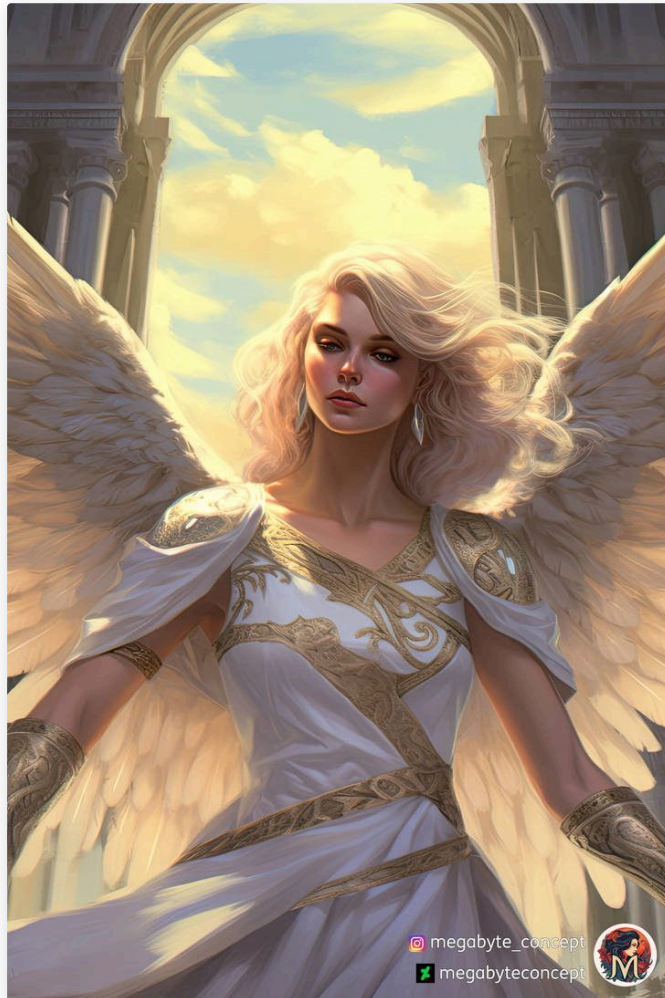
*The Amber Temple*



*Inajira the arcanaloth*

## *An interlude: Echoes of Creation*

There is a story that runs alongside this one, a night that belonged to different hands. Three strangers met at a crossroads near a city called Luminara, once a place of invention and inspiration, now under a fog that stopped its painters painting, its inventors inventing, its actors remembering how to imitate. A half-orc fighter, Meyil, hunting a glowing orb for a wizard who had promised him an army. An artificer of gears and mechanisms named Unity, with a watchful iron companion he called See-Sharp. And a sorcerer, Ithuriel, an aasimar who did not yet know why her dying mother had named her that.



*Ithuriel*

The city had been seized by the Inception Guild, wizard-academics who fancied themselves the most innovative minds alive, and beneath the fog the three found a hidden Innovation Guild who dreamed, every night, of a place full of color and sound they called the Nexus. They tracked the trouble to a crystal in a cave, a transmitter draining the town's minds, and stepped through it into the Realms of Creation.

This is where the campaign told itself its own secret. In the vastness of the multiverse there is a place called the Imagination Nexus, bound by neither time nor space, formed of

the collected imagination and dreams and wishes of every thinking being in every world. Every forgotten dream, every daydream that fades, every story never told, all of it drains into the Nexus. Over ages it grew dense enough to form a system that releases its surplus as energy, and in the worlds below, that surplus is magic. A spell that summons a construct, a fireball that carries heat and force out of nothing, these are information a caster draws up out of the Nexus. Magic items are the physical shapes of powerful tales lost in our world and given form in theirs.

A guide named Rime welcomed them and explained that a man called Malakhar, leader of the Inception Guild, had found his way here and begun swallowing the Nexus. Malakhar had once been a great wizard, until an experiment froze his eyes in time and left him blind forever, and everyone who had praised him left, until no one remembered him at all. Then one night he dreamed he could see again, into a world where a single second showed a thousand lives unspooling at once, and his blind eyes led his dreams to a door into the Realms. His plan was simple. The world had forgotten him, so he would unmake the whole universe until only he was left, and then he would forget it too.



*Rime, of the Realms of Creation*



*Malakhar*

They learned three powers of that place, to sketch things into being, to rewrite a single event, to reshape the ground under them, and they used all three against him, and beat him, and Rime sent them home. Ithuriel had heard, by then, of a band of adventurers back in Neverwinter who called themselves the Bits Defenders, and thought she might like to find them.

### *The Amber Temple, deeper*

Inside the temple the party found more of Exhander's old lecture halls, more of his students' choices scrawled on old boards, and the lich himself, level upon level down, weak and forgetful. Helmi convinced Exhander they were old friends, and the lich played along and tried to fish for who they were. Asked about the faceless god, Exhander said it was one of many gods the wizards who came here to study had worshipped over the centuries. He had built this place to keep the secrets of magic intact through time, and had never involved himself in the affairs of the thousands who crossed his threshold. Some called the statue the Dark Powers. He had not cared. Perhaps that was why, in time, his magic and then his mind had grown weak.

Helmi looked satisfied, glanced at the others, "shall we?" and Michael said, "we shall," and the party set on a level-eighteen lich of their own free will. It nearly killed them. A word of power stunned them, a blight tore through them, and when Exhander raised his hand with a word of power to kill Helmi outright, the whole thing hung on a single desperate counterspell, which held, and Gesh finished him. They took his spellbook.

They rested, and drank a potion that was supposed to bring good dreams. In Barovia there are no good dreams, only the absence of the bad ones, so all it gave was a night without nightmares, which is its own mercy. But this time it opened onto a world of color, a sky painted in vibrant yellows and pinks and violets, dragons of cloud flying beside birds with wings of crystal, and a strong blue presence approaching. "I am Sehanine Moonbow. I have called you here to teach you how to be free of Sehanine Nightweaver's influence before you face Strahd. Nightweaver means to steal your lives during that fight. She must not have the chance."



*Sehanine Moonbow*

"Sehanine Moonbow? Wasn't Nightweaver Sehanine?"

"We are both Sehanine. But Nightweaver is the part of my power that the Dark Powers corrupted. It is a long story. When I took refuge in the lands of the mist, I thought I was safe, and I let my guard down for one moment, and in that moment the Dark Powers corrupted a part of me."

"Refuge? From whom?"

"From one called Mad Foe Emir. You know him as the MythMaster."

"Who is he, exactly?"

She looked up as if she might find the answer in the stars. "A tremor passed through the Forgotten Realms, a disturbance in the cosmic balance. An entity received gifts from the gods of these lands, from Asmodeus, from Kelemvor, and even from me, Selune. It was chosen for a single task of universal importance, and granted leave to use any means to accomplish it. He called it the repair of the universe."

"Then why did you run, if the gods gave him permission?"

"Because I saw things you would not believe. I saw what Mad Foe Emir dreams, and I knew that only I, as the Aspect of Dreams of Selune, could truly understand what the world would be after his plan. And as I watched him sleep with his eyes closed, I realized that when I stand in his mind it is as if his eyes are open on the other side, and it was as if he were looking back at me. I was afraid, but it was too late. I knew he was coming for me."

She told them how to end Nightweaver. The Dark Powers had used this very temple as the anchor of the curse. While they had been in the Nightmare World, a rule Nightweaver imposed there kept Moon Bow from doing her any direct harm, which was why she had only ever been able to offer indirect help, killing monsters, restoring memories. But now that they had reached the Dream World, she could tell them the truth. They had to call Nightweaver here, into the temple, and destroy her.

They gathered salt and amber from the temple, blood from a coward they had spared, and six blessed lanterns, five of which the Coin Beast made for Gambit at the price of a coin. They set the lanterns in a wide circle, warded three of them with magic that held the monsters off, and spoke the nine psalms of the ritual one by one, while a thick fog filled the room and creatures they could not reach cast wind to snuff the flames. It came down to the last psalm with two lanterns guttering, and then Nightweaver's corruption was summoned into the world, six-armed and furious, striking left and right. Gambit found a poison that held her still, and Helmi and Gesh and Michael brought her down. With a deafening sound she fell, and the fog scattered.



*The corruption, summoned*

In a treasure room among the coins and the ruined armor, in a chest, they found an old journal. It was written in the first person, and it began, *I am ancient. I am the land.* It was the confession of Strahd von Zarovich, set down for his own remembrance, in case even his memory should one day fade. How he had been a warrior, good and just, worn down to dust by his wars and his family's honor. How his army had settled the valley of Barovia and he had built Castle Ravenloft, and brought his family to rule again, and with them his young and handsome brother Sergei, who reminded him of everything he had lost, whom he quickly came to hate. How a girl of the valley called Tatyana had shone above all others, and he had called her Perfection, and she had called him old one, elder, and finally brother, and given her heart to Sergei. How, on the day of their wedding, in his despair, he had heard whispers of an ancient power, a temple in the south, and made a pact with the darkness for eternal life, and killed his brother and sealed the pact with his blood. How the guards' arrows pierced him and he did not die and did not live, but became undead. How Tatyana fled from him and flung herself a thousand feet from the walls, and no trace of her was ever found, but no soul can leave his land, so her soul must be here still, trapped in one body after another, always slipping away. How he had taken the name Vampyr, and cursed the living for the life they still held. And how the two things he feared were the sun, and his brother's

accursed sword, and a sigil of his house, which he must destroy, for even the sight of them made him weak.

Strahd's curse is that he cannot die, and the whole land carries the weight of it with him. And at the end of the journal, the Tome of Strahd, there was a spell that controls where Castle Ravenloft moves. The party understood, all at once, that they could now bring the castle to them, and finally cross its threshold.

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## Castle Ravenloft

When Nightweaver fell, blue light gathered around them and they felt their power grow. Sehanine Moonbow gave each of them a gift to help against Strahd, and warned she might take it back the moment they used it carelessly.

Arnold asked Mordenkainen the thing that had been sitting in him for a while. "I know this may be too much, but you aren't my uncle, are you?" Mordenkainen studied him. "It can't be. After all this time. Bob DeSoya?" "Bob is my father." They had lost each other in a storm of time, the old wizard said, Bob flung into the future to a year Mordenkainen never managed to find. Family, then, after all.

They planned. Vampires cannot cross running water, so they chose to teleport the castle into the middle of Lake Baratok. The Tome's spell had safeguards against invalid locations, and open water was clearly one, but Arnold, who can bend a spell to his will, worked past the safeguards, and more than that, forced the spell to hold the castle fixed in place for a hundred years, long enough that no vampire would ever climb out of it and fall on the people of Barovia again. Then they sent word to every ally, the Resistance, Invictus, Blinsky, all of them, to gather at the Old Tower, the new base, and prepared for war.

Before the castle came, Helmi called Invictus and Michael held him still, and Helmi performed a rite of atonement, and black smoke poured from the celestial's eyes and scattered. When Invictus came back to himself he remembered: when he first walked into Barovia the magic had carried him straight to the castle, and Strahd had corrupted his mind with words and sent him to play at being a god for the people of Krezk. "You are Helmi," he said. "I was sent by Tymora to guide you to the next step in your faith, and I lost my way. The goddess must have sent you here to find me." He taught Helmi to focus deeper in prayer, so that Helmi could reach the Wings of Faith, spectral wings of light that lifted him above his enemies.

Lenna came to Michael, worried he was hurt, but Michael was still thinking of Sister Garaele, and was uneasy about the rat Inajira had carried, which had small surgical marks

around its head. Perhaps the rat was Sister Garaele, his true love. He found no proof it was anything but a rat.

The plan held. Arnold would move the castle in near the army, Strahd's monsters would pour out and the whole of Barovia would fight them, and the party would slip in behind. In the inner courtyard they heard the battle cries of Invictus and Blinsky and Esmeralda and Lenna and Viktor Vallakovich and the people of Krezk, and of a hundred monsters in the courtyard, eighty-nine were successfully drawn off. Invisible, the party crept past the rest and cut a circle in the chapel's stained glass and climbed through. On the central altar lay a decayed body that felt sanctified, with unreadable letters carved into it, and a socket exactly the shape of the Symbol of Ravenkind, which they did not fill, for fear of losing the symbol.

They climbed. Rahadin, Strahd's right hand, saw Gesh and leapt at him with terrible speed, and as the others closed in they began to hear voices of grief, "Rahadin killed me, Rahadin killed my family," clouding their minds. They beat him. Michael, with his fine hearing, caught a voice from somewhere in the towers, "why did you betray me, Tatyana."



*Rahadin*

In the library they found two halflings transcribing books under an old man's watch, bound by a compulsion so total that when they tried to warn the party they could only write "we cannot stop transcribing," then scrape the words away. Helmi solved it by sweeping every book into his bag of holding, so that the command was fulfilled and the halflings freed. The two, Paizo and Zici, leapt into Gambit's arms, weeping that Strahd had captured them and forced them to work. Gambit had one thought: two more rogues for his army of halfling rogues.

Higher up they found Strahd's brides, and a beautiful young man named Escher complaining that the count no longer paid him any attention, laughing cruelly about Ireena, Strahd's new acquisition, and the master's odd habit of spending time with her in the catacombs. Helmi burst in with a false daylight and in a few exchanges all four vampires fell. And higher still, at the top of the tower, they found Strahd, looking down on his army as the Resistance closed on it, a huge blue-skinned brute with red eyes beside him.

"So. You have come at last to take my land. I have waited for this moment so long. I knew there was something special about you from the moment you entered Barovia. I have watched you grow and learn, and I am impressed by your strength and your determination. But you are still not worthy of me. I am Strahd von Zarovich, and I am the lord of this domain. I am immortal, and I am invincible."

"We don't want to rule Barovia," Helmi said. "Just open the mist so we can leave."

"You see all these mountains and valleys. They are all mine, and everything in them. You are no exception. You became my property the moment you stepped into the fog. Bow, or perish."

Vampires and werewolves climbed the tower walls and black wraiths rose from the ground. "We will fight for our freedom," Helmi said, "but if you truly are the supreme lord, what do you say to a fight up high?" Strahd agreed, and the two of them took their duel into the air. The brute vampire hit Gesh and drank his blood at frightening speed. Arnold walled off the monsters with ice. Michael and Gambit were swarmed by wraiths. Helmi cast his daylight and the monsters began to lose ground.

When Helmi struck Strahd, the count's blood flew through the air, pulled toward something behind them, and they saw it: a great heart hanging in the highest tower, pulsing, and the instant the blood reached it Strahd looked healed. Strahd touched Helmi and for a moment charmed him, but a protection held. For a moment Strahd tried to steal his very body, and failed. Badly wounded, Gesh forced to flee the fight to recover, Helmi drove the sword home at last. As the blade went into Strahd's heart, Sergei's voice rose out of the steel: "This is for Tatyana, brother-killer." Strahd dissolved into a mist that took his shape, and the strong light destroyed it at once. The land shuddered, and the monsters began to flee or to rot.

For the first time in hundreds of years, the sun smiled through the clouds. A ray of light came down and lit the five of them, as if blessing them for what they had done, and below, in the courtyard, everyone leapt and cheered and lifted their hands to feel the warmth.



*Dawn over Barovia*

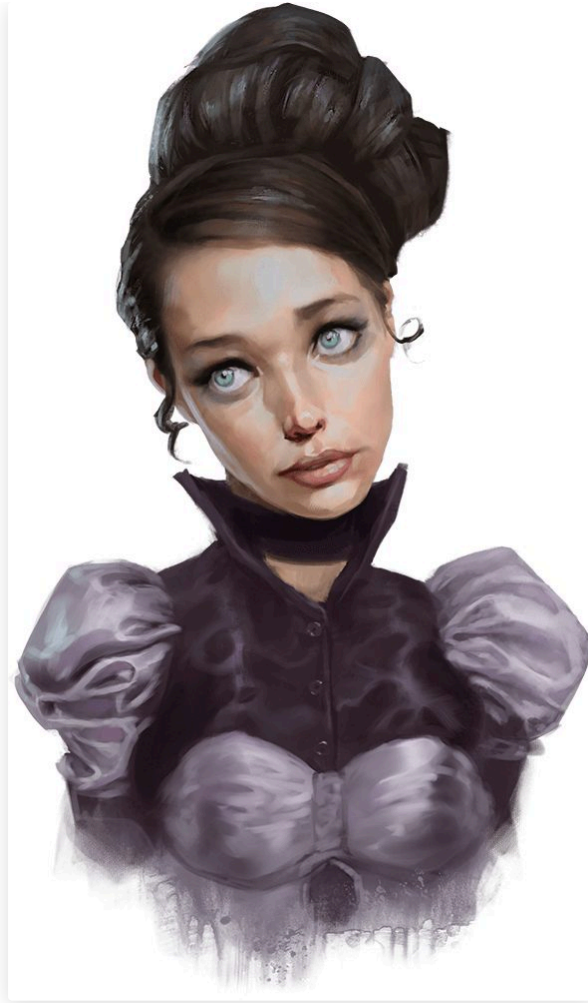
That was the end of the Curse of Strahd. But it was not the end of the story. Soon, they would come to visit me.



# Book Three: The Center of the World

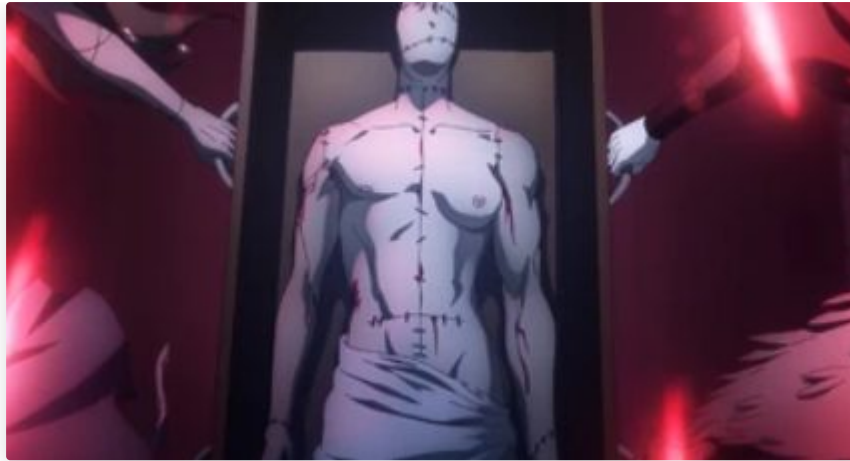
With Strahd gone they cleared the castle. In the highest tower, on a wall of specially built stone, hung a tapestry with the barely visible outline of five figures, and at the top a title, Prism Harmony Bane, which stirred an old and very strange story in Michael. In it, five heroes are fated to fight a powerful beast with thirteen faces, whose names are all written in the same signs, and only by using the signs to find the beast's true name do they beat it. The story was written by someone named Rime, and no one knows anything else about the author. They turned the tapestry over and found a signature that chilled them: *I am waiting for you.* MM.

In a room scratched with claw marks they found a woman shivering in the bedclothes, already turned. Her name was Gertruda, and they remembered her: the daughter of the weeping woman in the little village at the edge of Barovia, not dead after all, but a prisoner, a slave for Strahd. They could not help her yet, but they promised to come back.



*Gertruda*

In the crypts below they found a doctor named Alva working over a body, speaking to a sword that was no longer there. "Lord Strahd, now that I feel you no longer live, I have dared to perfect your clones and to achieve the dream of every true alchemist, the Supreme Androgyne, the Rebis. I took pieces of Ireena and joined them to your clones, but the girl's noble soul resists. Forgive me, but I will have to wake the dark soul of your father, King Barov, to catalyze the union." A great charge of lightning ran through the body on the table, and two beams of light swam out toward two opposite crypts, a red line to a crypt bearing the face of King Barov, a blue line to a crypt where Ireena's dead body lay, and out of the blue beam came Ireena's voice: "Do not let the king invade the undead one." They pushed the Rebis to Ireena's body and her soul was freed from the monster, and Helmi and Gesh brought the thing down. On the doctor's table they found letters between Bollenbach and Alva about a wizard whose mind had been written over the mind of a rat, and learned that though the information had transferred, the magic had not.



*The Rebis*

They asked Sehanine what would become of Barovia. The land was still close to the mists, she said, and before long the Dark Forces would return to recover what they had lost, but until then she, Sehanine Moonbow, would watch over the people. They went back and settled what was left, and saved Gertruda from her vampirism, and she asked to stay with them forever for the favor.

To go home, they meant to draw a magic circle back to a circle Arnold knew in Neverwinter. Arnold called Viktor Vallakovich to help him draw it, and they finished the work and tried to charge it, and something would not take. "Interesting," Mordenkainen said, looking over Arnold's shoulder. "The fourth axis is out of phase." And Arnold understood that the wrongness he had felt about the light on his first day in Barovia had been true all along. They were hundreds of years in the future. The circle failed because that circle, and perhaps Neverwinter itself, no longer existed.

The only way left was the mist. They said their goodbyes, and stepped into the cold vapor, and came out somewhere very strange.

### *NeoWinter*

In front of them a city made of many-colored lights blinked and turned and pulsed in an enigmatic dance. People made of light walked to and fro, passing straight through them, ignoring them. Arnold looked into the ethereal and saw with astonishment that all around them the ground was flat to the horizon, empty, nothing on it at all. The whole city of magic was a projection over nothing. In the middle of it stood a great sign: *To MythMaster. Come here, heroes.*



*NeoWinter*

They walked into an enormous hall like a throne room, and there the MythMaster rose from his seat and came toward them with open arms.



*The MythMaster, at the center of the world*

"Welcome. At last, to the center of the world."

It was the same line he had greeted them with in the Library of Dreams, so long ago. Read plainly, it sounds like a host welcoming guests to his kingdom. But this was not the Library anymore, and the center of the world, it turned out, is wherever the heroes happen to be standing. The MythMaster breathed out as if a deep sorrow had finally lifted, because at last his existence had been noticed by the imaginary world.

"I have waited for you a long time."

They asked him to send them home. He had sent them on the errand. They had done it.

"I don't think I want to do that. Do you see this book? This is the book of my Life." He showed them its last page, and read it aloud, and it was the very conversation they were having, word for word, ending on a blank line. "The day you entered that mist was the last day a word was written in my book. In the six hundred years since, I have worked out what is happening. This universe has a special rule that makes it turn, so to speak, around you. And you see, from the moment you stepped out of the mist where I have no authority, the pages began to write themselves again."

"And how is that our fault, that you found some magic book?"

"No, no. This book is part of a covenant between me and the Imagination Nexus. There is a reason this happens, and I think it is clear. You are the Protagonists of this world, and I am only a part of it." They fell silent. "So here is what I have decided. Since I am only an insignificant part of your story, another step, another dark corner that Yso, the Eye of the Universe, does not look at, I will make the best move I can. This is the only way I can come close to being a protagonist. I will choose the ending of the story. You, the heroes, will die here."

The last fight rose around them. Thirteen platforms joined by a great central floor, and on it the MythMaster and his monsters, four powerful mages, five creatures that fought like legends, and the MythMaster himself in thirteen forms. To beat him they had to name each form as it came, while dodging everything else, and the moment a name was spoken aloud, that face teleported away to an empty platform and became the next.

A Dimmer Foe, a small dim light. Deaf Memoir, a silent shadow. Fade Memoir, a ghost. Mad Foe Emir, a warrior with a twisted mind. Maim of Deer, a swift thing with antlers that pierce steel. Am Dome Fire, a ball of flame. I Defer Ammo, a shield that turns any attack. A Fried Omme. A Dime For Me, a silver coin that teleports at will. Fa mi re do me, a melody that charms all who hear it. Of A Rimed Me, an ice statue that freezes its enemies solid. Redo If Am Me, a mirror of whoever beat it. And the last, the true one.



*Mad Foe Emir, one of thirteen faces*

They kept each other alive and guessed the names in turn, and when the last name was spoken, "I am Freedom," the MythMaster exploded into a shining storm, and his voice, younger somehow, faded through the air whispering a last testament. A strong light opened a portal. Neverwinter, in the year 1491, lay on the other side of it.

### *Epilogue, in which each of them sees the future*

Back home, the first thing they did was find their own place. Well, the second thing. The first thing was to celebrate every night until dawn. They pulled together a fortune of fifty thousand gold and put the inn on its feet, the Bits Pub and Inn, and travelers came from far and wide to hear them, and in a corner, at a table, a dwarf with a lion's mane listened close and smiled. They made a secret base in the cellar and filled it with artifacts and precious books, and they visited the mine at Phandalin, where things went better and better.

Arnold kept studying magic under Mordenkainen, and one day, sure he had surpassed his master, took his share of the pub and built a workshop of magic and potions and very good cocktails. Helmi drove himself harder than ever to grow in the eyes of the gods and his own, won a title of nobility at last, and made a proud circuit of his hometown so his old doubters

could choke on it, and I hear he has recently taken up blacksmithing as a hobby. Gesh became a bounty hunter and gathered an unimaginable fortune, though it will never be enough for him, and I am sure he will gather a larger one still before his days are done. Michael was an excellent innkeeper, soon opened a second Bits Pub and Inn in Baldur's Gate, took up other ventures when he found a moment away from Sister Garaele, and the last I saw of him he was searching for his lost brothers, though I do not yet know how that little family reunion ended. Gambit trained over a hundred rogues into his army of halfling rogues, and his book became a bestseller on the black market, and everyone knows him as the maker of Bad Time, which some call the finest poison of all ages, though he told me he wishes people would stop reminding him of that "failure."

Ah. I have run out of ink. I am undead, and have been for longer than I can remember, which is the trouble with me: I lose things, whole years, whole selves. I wonder if anything will come back when I get back my memories from when I was the avatar of Kelemvor. But no, let me not stray, this is their story, not mine. And when I close this book, I am sure their story will keep writing itself. True stories are not found on a page, dead. They live through the people who tell them. That is what I do. I go from place to place, an undead woman with a borrowed name, and I tell their story.

*Mana, the undead*